

it can be a challenge. However, that said, networks like Jio are spreading all across metro and tier 1 and 2 cities and once those are all connected, we're sure the push will be towards more rural areas.

SOLAR

The reliability of electricity in remote parts of the country is still not ideal. Sure, we have most villages connected and on the grid, but they're a long, long way away from getting 24-hour power. This is where renewables come in, and especially solar, given how much sunlight our country receives. With the cost of solar falling constantly, it will soon be affordable for villages to invest in a few panels to run some basic amenities.

Also, NGOs and charities will play their part in subsidising the costs even further, or even doing free installations of solar panels. Once the people have more reliable power, you can be sure that they're going to be looking for more to do, and figure out more ways to help themselves.

TIMING AND COST

Cutting prices is never easy. It's usually deep into a category's lifecycle that everything just aligns for costs to be drastically cut. The time is perfect right now for cheap hardware that's decent to make it into the hands of India's poor. Manufacturers in China are now competing with one another to drive down costs, Jio brought down mobile data costs to perhaps the lowest in the world, and we're all finally getting our act together and taking the next billion seriously. While earning power is rising, the costs of entry-level smartphones are stagnating, which makes them more affordable to a lot of people. Mobile CPUs have been getting much less power hungry thanks to new chip fabs over the past five or six years, and that's finally trickling down to the entry level, which makes for a pretty decent smartphone experience on a budget.

INTERESTING PROJECTS

Neighbourly

(<https://dgit.in/neighbourly>)

A service by google, Neighbourly is a local networking app that uses the power of recommendations from neighbours (who you are more likely to trust than some stranger online). Also available only on Android devices, and only in a few cities in India, the app uses your location to recognise your locality, and then allows you to either ask or answer questions. Using gamification, you get rewarded with badges when users like your answers and upvote them. Pretty standard Reddit / Quora style that. However, remember that Reddit and Quora are usually strangers upvoting your answers, here it would be your neighbours, who you might know well (or not at all), and it gives you one more thing to talk and be social about. The good thing is that the answers are far more detailed and on point than the standard "reviews" you see on services such as Google Maps. Plus, let's not forget that when we really know our locality well, or have lived there for decades, we end up knowing every nook and cranny, and every hole in the wall shop, and that data is pretty unique. You should give this app a shot, you might like it. For the next billion though, this app will be good when they move into a strange village or city, or even when they're passing through one. Getting local help and recommendations is always a good thing, and if you can do so in your native language, all the better.

GET READY!

While I have covered my own opinion about what the net will look like in 2030 in my editorial page, what I also cannot deny is that we're going to meet the next billion online, and they will come in waves over the next decade. While we will definitely learn a ton from them, and also have our minds blown by some of the raw talent that is going to show up, we will also be a little shell shocked.

Many of us are used to the Internet being what it is now, which is western dominated with us brown and black fellows being the minority. How will that change when we are the majority? When the audience is mostly brown and black people, it stands to reason that they're going to connect better with their own countrymen who share the same experience, or speak in the same language. It will be no different to the channel packs we used to have, or the à la carte options we

have now, where we choose what's relevant to us and completely ignore things in different languages, or interests. This fractured version of the Internet will actually be less social than now, and return

to being more transactional for the next billion.

In a sense, think back to your early days of Internet adoption. When you first came online, you were perhaps clueless about what you should do next. Not because there was nothing to do, but because there was so much to choose from. These days, the choice has gone up by orders of magnitude – so you can only imagine what we'd be like if today was the first day we were on the Internet! Except, imagine that today was your first day on the internet, but everything was in Russian... maybe if we all thought about that, we'd be less inclined to bully or make fun of the next billion when they come online and try to interact with us. A little patience and a helping hand will go a long way towards helping us Indians dominate the Internet! :-)

References:

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